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retirement of the season. Russell's immediate frustration stemmed from the lack of pace on the straight rather than the collision that caused his spin. In his television interview later, he labelled it a "racing incident" rather than blaming his former teammate. Surprisingly, Hamilton was given a five-second penalty for the incident, which cost him a chance at a podium finish.

"When it happens so often, you just get used to it," a distraught Russell said post-race. "For whatever reason, the battery did not recharge at Turn 1, and I got to the top of Eau Rouge with zero per cent battery. I got swamped by three cars, and I shouldn't have been in that position in the first place, and that is why I am most angry," he explained.

Mercedes team principal Toto Wolff later explained that all the customer teams had also suffered a battery glitch in the first corner that prevented the batteries from

Pressure mounts: Kimi Antonelli's victory in the Belgian Grand Prix was his sixth of the season. Yet two scoreless finishes in the last four races have kept the Italian within touching distance of the chasing pack. REUTERS

recharging. That also explains why Antonelli fell behind Max Verstappen on the opening lap before eventually overtaking him later in the race.

"We have an incredibly strong engine and a fast car, but the package just isn't reliable enough yet. That's something we need to fix because it's costing us valuable points in the constructors' championship," Wolff told reporters.

Russell's post-crash radio was muted on the main broadcast, but a widely circulated clip on social media shows the Mercedes driver hurling expletives at the team in a fit of rage.

It is the most enraged the 28-year-old has been this season. He now has a 50-point deficit to make up to his junior teammate. With the factory yet to get to the root of the battery issue, it feels as though this will not be the end of his troubles heading into Hungary.

"Despite winning here, we are still finding issues with these regulations. It is something we are all working as hard as we can to get on top of, but

we've clearly got more learning ahead of us. We will need to keep improving if we are to maximise our points-scoring potential," admitted Mercedes engineering director Andrew Shovlin.

Ferrari earned a rich haul of points on a track where it was expected to be at a significant straight-line pace disadvantage to its rivals. Charles Leclerc's second-place finish, aided by a timely Virtual Safety Car, and Hamilton's fourth place despite the threat of another penalty for an unsafe release in the pit stop, have left the Prancing Horse just 73 points behind Mercedes in the Constructors' Championship.

With fewer power-sensitive tracks to come in the remaining races on the calendar, the Silver Arrows will have to find a way around their recurring reliability issues to remain favourites for both championships. Otherwise, Antonelli's stunning breakout season notwithstanding, Mercedes could find itself dragged into a far more nervous title fight than it had anticipated.

Costly clash: George Russell's Belgian Grand Prix came to a premature end after contact with Lewis Hamilton's Ferrari left him stranded in the gravel.

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